

tion in everything from fancy offices in highrises to humble kirana stores.

75F is a company that supplies solutions for automating and managing commercial buildings, including the equipment responsible for maintaining the air quality. As the WHO, CDC and other bodies started releasing new guidelines, new products began to be launched to support those guidelines across geographies. Gaurav Burman, APAC President of 75F says, “several business leaders have also leveraged the period of the lockdown and the work from home trend to scale up their commercial offices and workspaces with better technology in preparation for the return to normalcy. This has led to digital transfor-

Prem Kumar, Founder & CEO of Snapbizz, a company that sells inventory management, data analytics and billing solutions similar to the ones used by e-commerce giants to kirana stores, explains the complex series of events that lead to Kirana stores seeing an uptake in digitisation because of the pandemic: “This year our SnapBizz team has successfully helped neighborhood Kiranas gear up efficiently to compete against the larger ecommerce players in this industry. Kiranas have always been facing intense competition from major e-commerce grocery players who are aggressive in their campaigns to capture market share. The entrance of big players in the FMCG

nologies such as NFC and RFID tags is going to make payments more automated and only increase the volume of digital payments. Mr. Amit Kumar, Founder of Galaxy card, explains, “2020 caused a lot of upheavals to the FinTech industry. Many lenders had to completely stop lending once the lockdown was announced, and those who did lend or had loans already saw a sharp increase in their defaults. On the other hand, a lot of customers started to look out for digital lenders in this pandemic, not just out of a need for loans, but also to keep social distancing and avoid contact with people. We even saw a change in repayment patterns from customers, as they become happier to pay later despite accruing interest, but to ensure their liquidity was not affected, and only paying from their disposable cash. We also saw a huge increase in smartphone penetration in 2020, led on by TikTok, and by COVID, as people were forced to stay at home. This led to the surge in customer need for online loans as they were newly introduced to a whole new world.”

Kumar goes on to elaborate what to expect in the year ahead, “2021 will be a very unique year, with the economy getting back up on its feet. A lot of new mobile subscribers and first-time internet users will look for services to excite them, and this is a boon for all the consumer brands. FinTech will benefit largely from these new consumers as the convenience will drive a lot of referrals and word of mouth. We’re already seeing UPI grow by leaps and bounds. With the government’s continued push on digital payments, such as mandatory FastTAG for every vehicle, we’ll see even more digital payments adoption as people begin to travel as COVID fades away.”

Fintech startups are playing a crucial role in countering the economic slowdown induced by the pandemic, and also helping those rendered jobless get back on their feet. Mr Anurakt Jain, Co-founder, Klub, says, “With increased digital adoption and solutions incorporating the market volatility, the Fintech sector is well positioned for growth in a post-Covid market. Through its unique alternate



Credit: Snapbizz

A Kirana store owner using Snapbizz technologies

mation in the workplace in creating smart, digitally connected spaces that use less energy, meet sustainability and safety goals, and boost workplace collaboration and productivity. There is also a trend towards optimising work spaces with an eye on long term sustainability. Our offerings in the space that have been popular include 75F’s preset systems to digitally monitor, analyze and control an environment and visibility to customised data analytics at all times from any remote location. As occupant comfort and environmental sustainability are increasingly being given priority in commercial spaces, the potential for smart buildings has grown considerably in 2020. While the commercial and retail sectors are already moving towards building automation, we expect the hospitality and health sector to follow suit in 2021.”

sector has been another cause for concern among them. However, as it was evident, it was the Kiranas who provided a lifeline to the country when the lockdown struck with the Pandemic. This renewed trust in the neighbourhood kirana by people also prompted them to embrace digitisation to further enhance their relationship with customers. We see this as a positive trend and will only see wider adoption of technology by kiranas at the grass root level in 2021.”

07 DIGITAL PAYMENTS

While the reliance on digital transactions dipped in the months following the demonetisation, digital payments got another shot in the arm with the pandemic. The increase in use in tech-